More worrying was the arrival of intelligence from Nazir Khan Ullah in Bukhara that the Russians were now finishing their preparations to invade Khiva. ‘The Russians have collected a great number of camels, carriages and boats on the bank of the Caspian Sea,’ he wrote. ‘They have resolved to send their army and provision by way of the Caspian to the vicinity of Kir, a distance of three days’ journey from Khiva.’[44] Still ignorant of Dost Mohammad’s detention in Bukhara, Macnaghten feared that the Russians could again be plotting with the Amir, planning to install him in Herat, which was now in ‘a comparatively defenceless state’.[45]

Only Burnes seems to have understood that the Russian move was simply a direct response to British aggression in Afghanistan. ‘Russia has put forth her force merely to counteract our policy,’ he wrote to his friend Captain G. L. Jacob. ‘By our advance on Kabul we thus hastened the great crisis.’ Even at this stage Burnes instinctively grasped how fleeting could be the hold of either Russia or Britain on such an independent people as the Afghans. ‘England and Russia will divide Asia between them,’ he wrote prophetically, ‘and the two empires will enlarge like the circles in the water until they are lost in nothing, and future generations will search for both in these regions as we now seek the remains of Alexander and his Greeks.’[46u]

Such realism was in increasingly short supply during the winter of 1839–40. Already the idea of permanently annexing Afghanistan was being discreetly discussed; there was even talk of moving the summer capital of the Raj from the inaccessible Himalayan ridge of Simla to the rich gardens of the Kabul valley, just as the Mughals had once migrated each May from Delhi and Agra to Kashmir and the lovely Nimla Gardens near Jalalabad.[47] Such over-confidence soon began to lead to a series of major strategic errors.

Firstly, rather than concentrating on consolidating Shah Shuja’s fragile rule in Afghanistan, and providing the resources needed to make the occupation viable and secure, Lord Auckland – like more recent invaders – instead took the premature view that the conquest was already complete and so allowed himself to be distracted by launching another war of aggression in a different theatre. ‘China promises to be amusing,’ wrote his sister Emily in a revealingly flippant letter around this time. ‘The Chinese are arming themselves and fitting up little innocent American ships, and collecting war junks; and it is my own belief that they are so conceited that they will contrive some odd way of blowing up all our 74s with blue and